before his birth. Virtually every year thereafter was eventful too, whether it was the separation of his parents, his exuberant college days, his training years, or the two momentous decades he spent as the head of Tata Sons. But this titan made the task even more complex through his unassuming manners that misled me into grossly underestimating the extent of the challenges he had faced within and without the group, throwing me off guard in estimating the enormity of the work before me.

The more I researched, the more painfully I realized how little I knew of Ratan; compounding the frustration was the fact that virtually nothing of what he had done was systematically recorded or organized. Surprisingly, the vaunted Tata Central Archives, Pune, too had very little about Ratan. That was exasperating. Unsurprisingly, therefore, I found out that a great deal of important information about the group, assumed to be correct and endlessly reprised, is in fact questionable, with even some reputed journals falling unwitting victims to false narratives.

Faced with a drought of material, I had to reach out to those who had worked closely with Ratan during his helmsmanship of the group. Many of them, having retired, were scattered around the world. But the chain search yielded a treasure trove of information for the biography. Impressed by the material I had hauled up through bottom trawling, Ratan expressed interest in seeing some of it, and I did not disappoint him. He was so excited with the finds that on a couple of days he sat with me reminiscing about his bygone days as he enthusiastically saw his presentations made decades ago and heard his speeches delivered during the meets.

But there still remained many gaps to be filled in the story of his life. Determined not to miss anything, I assiduously collected and analysed virtually everything ever written or spoken about Ratan, however hidden they lay. The material that piled up was humungous, for the tasks that he accomplished after he took over as chairman of the group in 1991 were gargantuan. Further, there was no comparable industrial leader in the world who had to grapple with such diverse challenges spread across a spectrum of enterprises, from steel to salt to software, that he led to achieve vertiginous growth. And Ratan did nothing on a small scale either.

The first task he set himself to was to cohere a flotilla of disparate companies, captained by not-so-friendly stalwarts moving in different directions and often engaged in infighting, into a strong and repurposed team lead by the mothership, Tata Sons. This entailed the analysis of the